While the web has been our main metaphor in recent decades, the future might belong to cocoons.

THE GLOBAL MIND–BODY SPLIT

The division into separate information cocoons could lead not just to economic rivalries and international tensions but also to the development of very different cultures, ideologies and identities. Guessing future cultural and ideological developments is usually a fool's errand. It is far more difficult than predicting economic and geopolitical developments. How many Romans or Jews in the days of Tiberius could have anticipated that a splinter Jewish sect would eventually take over the Roman Empire and that the emperors would abandon Rome's old gods to worship an executed Jewish rabbi?

It would have been even more difficult to foresee the directions in which various Christian sects would develop and the momentous impact of their ideas and conflicts on everything from politics to sexuality. When Jesus was asked about paying taxes to Tiberius's government and answered, 'Render unto Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and unto God the things that are God's' (Matthew 22:21), nobody could imagine the impact his response would have on the separation of church and state in the American republic two millennia later. And when Saint Paul wrote to the Christians in Rome, 'I myself in my mind am a slave to God's law, but in my sinful flesh a slave to the law of sin' (Romans 7:25), who could have foreseen the repercussions this would have on schools of thought ranging from Cartesian philosophy to queer theory?

Despite these difficulties, it is important to try to imagine future cultural developments, in order to alert ourselves to the fact that the AI revolution and the formation of rival digital spheres are likely to change more than just our jobs and political structures. The following paragraphs contain some admittedly ambitious speculation, so please bear in mind that my goal is not to accurately foretell cultural developments but merely to draw attention to the likelihood that profound cultural shifts and conflicts await us.

One possible development with far-reaching consequences is that different digital cocoons might adopt incompatible approaches to the most fundamental questions of human identity. For thousands of years, many